DIGITALAIKART · 2027 INTAKE EDITION

STUDY IN GERMANY

The Indian Student Playbook

APS · dMAT · Blocked account · uni-assist
Visa file · First 90 days · Blue Card

33 CHAPTERS	VERIFIED NOV 2026	2027 INTAKES

Every fee, deadline and rule checked against German government, DAAD, APS India and university sources.

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BEFORE YOU START

How to use this book

This is not a motivational guide about Germany. It is a working manual for one specific person: an Indian student or young professional trying to get into a German university for the 2027 intakes, without paying an agent to guess for them.

Three things make this edition different from the advice floating around on YouTube and WhatsApp groups. First, it is built on the 2027 intake reality, not the 2023 one. Two rules changed in the last eighteen months and both of them affect you directly: a new test called dMAT now sits inside the APS process for many master's applicants, and the amount you must show in a blocked account is on course to rise from the summer semester 2027. Second, every number here comes from a primary source, and each chapter names that source so you can check it yourself before you spend money. Third, it tells you where Germany is no longer cheap, because a plan built on the phrase “free education in Germany” will collapse the moment you open a TUM fee page.

How the book is organised

Part One helps you decide whether this is your route at all, with the numbers in front of you. Part Two is money: the blocked account, the monthly budget, scholarships you can actually win, and the legal maths of working while studying. Part Three is documents: APS, dMAT, uni-assist, your SOP, your language certificate. Part Four is the visa file, document by document, including the refusal reasons that are entirely preventable. Part Five covers your first fortnight in Germany, when most students lose money and time on things nobody warned them about. Part Six is what happens after graduation, where the 18-month job-seeker permit and the EU Blue Card salary thresholds decide your next five years. Part Seven is the toolbox: checklists, a budget worksheet, six email templates and a glossary of the German words that appear on every form.

How to read it if you are short on time

1. **Applying for summer semester 2027 (April start):** read chapters 10, 11, 16 and 18 today. Your APS clock and dMAT date are the binding constraints.
2. **Applying for winter semester 2027/28 (October start):** read chapters 5, 6, 12, 16 and 18. You have room to plan, and the blocked account figure is the number to watch.
3. **Still deciding:** read chapters 1 to 4. They will either save you two years or make your decision a confident one.

What is verified, and as of when

Every figure in this book was checked against a German government, DAAD, university or statutory-insurer source between 1 and 3 November 2026. Where a rule is a proposal and not yet law, the text says so in plain words. Where a number changes every January, the chapter tells you which date it changes on and what to check.

> **The one habit that protects you**
> Before you transfer a single euro, open the page of your German mission in India (india.diplo.de) and the checklist for your visa type. Rules on money, language certificates and documents are set per mission, and they change. A guide is a map. The mission's checklist is the road. When they disagree, the checklist wins.

What this book cannot do

It cannot get you admitted, and it cannot guarantee a visa. Admission is the university's decision and the visa is the mission's decision, and both are made case by case.

It is not legal or financial advice, and it is not affiliated with the German government, DAAD, APS India, uni-assist or any university. Fees quoted are the published fees at the time of writing; universities revise them.

Rupee conversions in this book are planning aids at roughly Rs 100 to 110 per euro. Use the rate on the day you actually transfer money, and add your bank's markup.

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PART ONE · CHAPTER 1

Germany in 2027: the numbers that actually matter

Start with the reason this book exists. In the winter semester 2025/26, 69,816 Indian students were enrolled at German universities. That is a rise of 17.5 per cent in a single year, almost 10,400 students added in twelve months, and it made Indians the largest group of international students in Germany for the first time, ahead of China. The figures were highlighted by DAAD India in August 2026.

69,816	+17.5%	13.5%	~70,000
Indian students in Germany, winter semester 2025/26	growth in one year	share of all international students	figure quoted by India's ambassador, October 2026

The DAAD and DZHW report Wissenschaft weltoffen 2026, published on 14 October 2026, put the wider picture at around 426,200 international students and doctoral candidates in that same winter semester, with international first-year enrolment at a record 130,000. India was the leading country of origin at roughly 69,000, China second at roughly 39,000.

Why does this matter to you? Because a large inflow changes the queue you are joining. More Indian applicants means APS verification files pile up between May and August, uni-assist takes longer, visa appointment slots disappear first in the big consular districts, and rooms near popular universities are gone by July. The demand is real, and so is the competition. Plan like someone who knows the queue is long.

What is pulling Indian students to Germany

Three things, in this order. Cost of tuition at public universities, which for most programmes outside Baden-Württemberg and TUM is still zero, with only a semester contribution. The post-study route, which gives a graduate an 18-month residence permit to look for work and then a straightforward path into the EU Blue Card. And the shift away from the old four destinations: rising costs, visa uncertainty and changing post-study work rules in the United States, United Kingdom, Canada and Australia have pushed Indian students towards Germany, and the growth is no longer only from metros.

India's ambassador to Germany, speaking to NDTV in October 2026, described a diaspora of around 332,000 Indian citizens plus roughly 70,000 people of Indian origin who have taken German citizenship, with more than 60,000 Indians moving to Germany annually over the past two years. He also said something every applicant should take seriously: learning German improves your job prospects, because Germany's workforce is ageing, with an average population age of around 45.

The three facts that decide whether you succeed

1. The APS certificate is not optional, and it is the slowest item

If you hold an Indian school-leaving certificate or an Indian degree, you almost always need an APS certificate before a German university will admit you, and before the visa section will process you. APS India states verification takes at least two weeks; in practice, files sent between May and August take far longer. Chapter 10 covers this in full.

2. The money you must show is real money, not a fee

For a student visa you must prove 992 euros a month, 11,904 euros for the year, usually in a blocked account. That money is yours; it is released to you at 992 euros a month after you arrive. It is a liquidity requirement, not a payment to the government. Chapter 5 explains the mechanics, chapter 6 explains the increase coming for 2027.

3. Your language certificate must be one India's missions accept

The German missions in India accept Goethe Institute or Max Mueller Bhavan, ÖSD, telc, TestDaF and DSH for German, and IELTS, Cambridge Assessment English or TOEFL for English. They explicitly do not accept Duolingo, Pearson PTE, or the TOEFL Home Edition for applications in India. If your agent told you PTE is fine, that is a costly mistake. Chapter 15 has the full rule.

The honest counter-argument

Germany is not a soft option. The German economy has been sluggish, and a degree does not hand you a job. English-taught master's programmes are full of Indian students competing for the same Werkstudent roles. The housing market in every big university city is tight enough that roughly 33,000 students were waiting for a dormitory place at the start of the winter semester 2025/26, according to the Deutsches Studierendenwerk. And the growth in Indian enrolments has brought scrutiny of private and hybrid programmes that charge tuition far above the public-university experience students expected.

None of that makes Germany a bad choice. It makes it a choice that rewards preparation and punishes wishful thinking. That is the whole premise of this book.

PART ONE · CHAPTER 2

What it really costs: the full three-year sheet

Most cost articles quote tuition and stop. Tuition is not your problem in Germany. Your problem is the cash you must produce before you board the flight, and then the monthly burn for two years. Let us put both on one page.

The pre-departure bill

These are the published charges at the time of writing. None of them is negotiable, and all of them are paid before you leave India.

Item	Amount	Notes
APS certificate	Rs 18,000	Non-refundable, paid to APS India. Chapter 10.
dMAT test (if applicable)	EUR 150	Paid to g.a.s.t. Only for listed master's subject groups from summer 2027.
uni-assist handling	EUR 75 + EUR 30	First course per semester, then each additional course.
National visa fee	Rs 8,300 / EUR 75	Adults. Minors Rs 4,200 / EUR 37.50. Plus the VFS service fee.
Blocked account	EUR 11,904	Not a fee. Your own living money, released monthly.
Blocked account provider fee	roughly EUR 60-150	Varies by provider, plus any transfer cost.
Flight, one way	Rs 35,000-60,000	Wide seasonal range.
Setup on arrival	EUR 1,000-1,600	Rent deposit of up to three months, bedding, SIM, kitchen basics.
Document costs in India	Rs 5,000-15,000	Notarised copies, courier to APS, photos, translations where needed.

Add it up for a tuition-free public master's and you need roughly EUR 14,500 to 15,500 of cash in the first three months, of which EUR 11,904 comes back to you month by month. At Rs 100 to 110 to the euro, that is about Rs 15 to 17 lakh of liquidity, not of spending.

The monthly burn

Germany's own student support rate is the honest baseline: 992 euros a month. That is what the government assumes a student needs, and it is what the visa requires you to show. Here is where it goes.

Head	Per month	What it covers
Rent (room in a shared flat)	EUR 300-800	Average across university cities was EUR 505 warm at the start of winter semester 2025/26.
Health and care insurance	EUR 141-146	Statutory student rate, TK figures from 1 January 2026.
Semester contribution	EUR 15-60	Paid per semester, not monthly. Around EUR 90-350 a semester, mostly the transport ticket.
Food and groceries	EUR 200-280	Cooking at home. Indian groceries cost more than in India, less than restaurants.

Head	Per month	What it covers
Phone and internet	EUR 10-25	Prepaid SIM plus home connection if your room needs one.
Broadcasting fee	EUR 18.36	Per household, not per person, if you rent your own flat.
Books, copies, software	EUR 15-40	Mostly free PDFs and library access. Budget for one or two books a semester.
Personal and travel	EUR 60-120	Haircuts, clothes, the occasional train.

In Leipzig, Chemnitz or Magdeburg the total can sit near 850 euros. In Munich, Frankfurt or Berlin it can pass 1,200. The blocked account amount is a national average, which is why students in cheap cities finish the year with savings and students in Munich finish it with a part-time job.

Three years, three scenarios

A two-year master's plus the job-search year, in three versions. All figures in euros. The tuition lines use published 2026 rates; TUM's rates rise from winter semester 2027/28 and chapter 3 lists the new numbers.

Line	Public, tuition-free	Baden-Württemberg	TUM master's
Tuition, 4 semesters	0	6,000	16,000-24,000
Semester contributions	600-1,400	600-1,400	400-500
Living, 24 months	19,800-28,800	19,800-28,800	19,800-28,800
Insurance, 24 months	3,400-3,500	3,400-3,500	3,400-3,500
Setup and travel	2,000-3,000	2,000-3,000	2,000-3,000
Rough total	26,000-37,000	32,000-43,000	42,000-60,000

Read that table as a range of possibilities, not a prediction. The single biggest variable is not tuition, it is the city you choose and whether you find a working-student job in your second semester.

> **The number nobody calculates: what you give up**
> Two years of a German master's is two years of not earning an Indian salary and two years of your parents' savings sitting in a blocked account. If you are borrowing, add interest: an education loan of Rs 20 lakh at 10.5 per cent over seven years costs roughly Rs 34,000 a month in EMI. Decide whether the degree is worth that before you pay the APS fee, not after.

PART ONE · CHAPTER 3

The free-tuition myth: exactly where you pay

Germany is not uniformly tuition-free, and the exceptions are exactly the places Indian students most want to go. If you are budgeting on a 2019 blog post, this chapter is the correction.

Where tuition is zero

Most public universities in most states charge no tuition for a standard first degree. You pay a semester contribution, which funds student services and, in most cities, a transport ticket. At TUM the semester fee is 97 euros in Munich, Garching, Weihenstephan and Heilbronn, and 82 euros in Straubing, for the summer semester 2026. Elsewhere it commonly falls between 90 and 350 euros, and the transport ticket is usually the largest line inside it.

That transport ticket is now called the Deutschlandsemesterticket and it is worth knowing precisely. From winter semester 2026/27 it costs 37.80 euros a month, 226.80 euros a semester, calculated as 60 per cent of the 63-euro national Deutschlandticket. It is valid on local and regional transport across Germany, not on long-distance ICE or IC trains. Where your university has opted in, the ticket is inside your semester contribution and you cannot opt out of it individually.

Baden-Württemberg: 1,500 euros a semester

Since winter semester 2017/18, public universities in Baden-Württemberg charge non-EU students 1,500 euros a semester, on top of the semester contribution. That covers Heidelberg, Freiburg, Tübingen, Stuttgart, Mannheim, Konstanz and Karlsruhe, which is a serious list of good universities. A two-year master's therefore carries 6,000 euros of tuition before you count anything else.

Bavaria and TUM: the big one

From winter semester 2024/25, TUM charges tuition to newly enrolling students from non-EU/EEA countries. TUM's own published ranges are 2,000 or 3,000 euros a semester for bachelor's programmes and 4,000 or 6,000 euros a semester for master's programmes, plus the semester fee. The exact amount depends on the programme.

The 2027 increase, confirmed by TUM

TUM states that tuition for non-EU/EEA students will rise for winter semester 2027/28: bachelor's programmes to 2,300 or 3,400 euros a semester, master's programmes to 4,600 or 6,800 euros. Students already enrolled keep the rate that applied when they started, for the programme they started.

If you are applying for winter 2027/28, budget the new numbers, not the old ones. A four-semester master's at the higher rate is 27,200 euros of tuition alone.

TUM does offer waivers and scholarships, but they are competitive and must be applied for by the deadline each time. Its international-student scholarship pays a one-off study grant of 500 to 1,800 euros a semester, decided on academic performance and financial need. That is help, not a solution.

Private universities and the programmes to be careful with

Private universities and some university-of-applied-sciences partnerships charge real tuition: 8,000 to 20,000 euros a year is common. Some are excellent. Some are not, and the difference is hard to see from India because the marketing looks identical.

Use these five checks before you pay a deposit to any programme that charges tuition.

1. **Is the institution state-recognised?** Check the programme on the German Rectors' Conference database and on anabin. If it is not listed, the degree may not open the doors you are paying for.
2. **Is it accredited, and for what?** Look for system accreditation or programme accreditation, not a logo on a brochure.
3. **Where are the graduates?** Ask for the actual employment record, not testimonials. A programme that cannot produce a list of where last year's cohort works is selling you a certificate.
4. **What does the visa section think of it?** For a private programme with tuition, the German missions require proof that the first two semesters of tuition are paid or a substantial deposit has been made. Budget for it.
5. **Does it lead to a real job-seeker permit?** Graduates of German universities get the 18-month permit. Confirm your programme is a German degree, not a foreign degree delivered in Germany, because the rules differ.

One more warning, and it is not a small one. The surge in Indian enrolments has brought renewed scrutiny of debt, recruitment practices and immigration risk tied to some private and hybrid programmes, and a visible gap between the affordable public-university experience most students expect and what some of them actually get. If an agent is steering you towards one specific private college with a commission structure, ask why.

PART ONE · CHAPTER 4

Is this your route? A ten-question filter

Answer honestly. Nobody is watching, and a wrong yes here costs two years and Rs 20 lakh.

Question	If no
1. Can you produce roughly EUR 12,000 of liquid funds, or a sanctioned education loan covering it, without selling the family's only asset?	The visa will not be issued. Fix funding first, or look at funded programmes only.
2. Does your degree and marks make you competitive for the programmes you want, in the subject you can actually explain in an interview?	Shortlist lower-tier universities or a related subject. Chapter 12 shows how.
3. Can you get an APS certificate with documents your college will confirm?	Without APS, most programmes and the visa route close. Chapter 10.
4. Do you have, or can you get within six months, a language certificate that India's missions accept?	The visa file is incomplete. Chapter 15 lists what counts.
5. Are you willing to live in a smaller city, or share a flat, to keep rent under 500 euros?	Your monthly burn will exceed the blocked account release.
6. Can you survive eight to fourteen weeks of visa processing without a confirmed travel date?	The timeline will break you. Read chapter 20.
7. Is a two-year master's the right instrument for your goal, rather than a job or a certification?	Do not buy a degree to solve a skills problem.
8. Are you prepared to learn German to A2 or B1 within your first year, even on an English-taught programme?	Your job prospects after graduation narrow sharply.
9. If you return to India after three years, is the degree still worth what you paid?	You are taking a one-way bet on a labour market you have not seen.
10. Have you spoken to two people who actually studied in Germany in the last three years?	Do that before you pay the APS fee. Not an agent. Students.

Six or more clean yeses and you are a serious candidate. Four or five and you have work to do before an application makes sense. Three or fewer and the honest answer is that Germany is a project for next year, not this intake.

The cheapest thing you can do this month

Open the DAAD International Programmes database, filter by your subject and by English as the language of instruction, and write down ten programmes with their deadlines and tuition. That single hour will tell you more about your chances than any counselling session. Then check each one on anabin and on the university's own page, because the database lags reality by a semester.

PART TWO · CHAPTER 5

The blocked account, explained properly

The blocked account, Sperrkonto in German, is the single most misunderstood item in the whole process. Students treat it as a fee. It is not. It is your own money, held in Germany, released to you in twelve equal instalments after you arrive.

The amount, and where it comes from

The figure is not invented by the visa section. It is tied to the maximum rate of BAföG, Germany's student support law. The current requirement, unchanged since 1 September 2024, is 992 euros a month, 11,904 euros for twelve months. The German missions in India state this explicitly in their student checklist and in their national visa FAQs.

A different amount applies if you are not yet admitted: applicants looking for a university place, Studienkolleg students and language-course visas must show 1,091 euros a month. The opportunity card uses the same 1,091 euro figure.

Purpose of stay	Per month	Per year
Degree studies, admission letter in hand	EUR 992	EUR 11,904
Applicant seeking a university place, Studienkolleg, language course	EUR 1,091	EUR 13,092
Opportunity card (job search)	EUR 1,091	EUR 13,092

How the mechanics actually work

1. **Open the account before the visa appointment.** The missions accept only an official opening confirmation that states the total amount paid in and the monthly available amount. A confirmation without both numbers is rejected.
2. **Choose any provider you like.** The Federal Foreign Office is explicit that you are free to choose, and it names no preferred bank. Providers used by Indian students include Fintiba, Expatrio, Coracle and Deutsche Bank. Compare the fee, the monthly release cost, and whether the provider gives the authorities a verification login.
3. **Fund it before you apply.** In practice you transfer from India, through your bank or the provider's payment partner. Allow for FX markup and a possible second transfer if the first is short.
4. **Get the confirmation into your visa file.** It is a mandatory document, not a supporting one.
5. **Activate it after arrival.** The account releases 992 euros a month once you have a German address and a German bank account, and once your identity is verified.
6. **Renew it for the residence permit.** When you extend your residence permit, the foreigners authority will again want proof of funds. Some students top up the blocked account; others show a part-time contract, a scholarship or a declaration of commitment.

Three ways to prove funds that are not a blocked account

A formal obligation letter, Verpflichtungserklärung, from a sponsor living in Germany, issued in front of the local immigration office. The Indian affidavit of support is not a substitute; the missions say so directly.

A German or EU public scholarship, if it covers at least 992 euros a month.

An education loan, which the missions accept as additional proof of financing, though the blocked account remains the cleanest route.

The five mistakes that cost students money

1. Opening the account after the appointment slot, then missing it. The confirmation takes days, sometimes two weeks.
2. Transferring 11,900 euros and discovering the provider deducted its fee from the deposit, leaving you short. Pay the fee separately.
3. Using a provider that does not give the mission a verification login. The missions warn about this in writing.
4. Assuming the money is spent. Plan your first two months on the assumption that the release begins only after your bank account and address exist, which can take three to four weeks. Carry cash or a card for that gap.
5. Forgetting the release fee. Some providers charge a small amount each time they release the monthly instalment.

PART TWO · CHAPTER 6

The 2027 change you need to plan for now

This chapter exists because of a bill in the Bundestag, and because almost nobody applying for 2027 has priced it in.

What is happening to BAföG

Because the blocked account is pegged to the BAföG rate, any rise in student support eventually raises the amount international students must show. In 2026 the German government moved on that.

The cabinet approved the 30th amendment to the BAföG on 12 August 2026. The Bundestag held its first reading on 15 October 2026 and sent the draft to committee. As of the date of this book it is a draft, not law. The published proposals are:

Item	Now	Proposed
Housing allowance, students living away from parents	EUR 380/month	EUR 440/month from 1 April 2027
Basic need, students	EUR 475/month	EUR 503/month from winter semester 2027/28
Basic need, second step	EUR 503/month	EUR 563/month from April 2029
Application route	Paper and portal	Digital through BAföG Digital, with exceptions

What that could mean for your blocked account

Nothing is official yet. The Federal Foreign Office has not published a 2027 blocked account figure, and it may calculate on a different basis or apply a new amount from a different date. But the arithmetic is simple, and it is worth doing so you are not surprised at the bank counter.

Scenario	Per month	Per year	Change
Today, in force	EUR 992	EUR 11,904	none
If the April 2027 housing rise flows through	EUR 1,052	EUR 12,624	+EUR 720
If the winter 2027/28 rise also flows through	EUR 1,080	EUR 12,960	+EUR 1,056

Treat the middle row as a planning number, not a fact

EUR 1,052 and EUR 12,624 are arithmetic on a proposed change. They are not an official requirement. Before you transfer money, check the amount on your German mission's page and on the Consular Services Portal. If your intake is summer 2027 or later, arrange a buffer of about EUR 1,000 so a late increase does not derail your visa appointment.

What to do about it, practically

1. If you are applying for summer semester 2027, your visa appointment will probably fall before any new figure is published. Plan for 11,904 and keep 1,000 euros of headroom in the same account or a separate one.

2 If you are applying for winter semester 2027/28, budget 12,960 in your funding plan. If the increase is smaller, you simply have more monthly cash.

3 If you are taking an education loan, ask the bank for a sanctioned limit that covers the higher figure plus one semester of fees. A top-up request after sanction is slow.

4 Do not lock a fixed rupee amount with a forex dealer months early. The euro-rupee rate moves, and a shortfall of a few hundred euros is the most common reason a visa file is held.

PART TWO · CHAPTER 7

Your real monthly budget, city by city

Rent decides everything. The Moses Mendelssohn Institute, working with the German student union body, measures student rents twice a year across all 88 German university cities with more than 5,000 students. At the start of winter semester 2025/26 the average warm rent for a student room crossed 500 euros for the first time, at 505 euros a month. In 70 of the 88 cities, that average was above the BAföG housing allowance of 380 euros.

City	Typical student room, warm	Comment
Munich	around EUR 800	Highest in the country. Dormitory place is the only realistic route below 500.
Berlin	around EUR 650	Huge supply of rooms, huge demand. Start looking in June for October.
Hamburg	around EUR 610	Competitive, and the semester ticket matters here.
Cologne	around EUR 583	Slightly cheaper than Hamburg, similar pressure.
Leipzig	around EUR 440-500	Popular and rising fast. Still far cheaper than the west.
Chemnitz	around EUR 270-300	Among the cheapest university cities in Germany.
Magdeburg, Greifswald	around EUR 375-400	Quiet, cheap, and close enough to Berlin for a weekend.

Those are averages for a room in a shared flat on the open market. A place in a Studierendenwerk dormitory is usually cheaper, sometimes by 200 euros a month, but supply is the problem: the dormitories can house only about one student in ten, and at the start of winter semester 2025/26 roughly 33,000 students nationwide were on waiting lists.

A worked monthly budget in a mid-sized city

Head	Amount	Notes
Rent, warm	EUR 430	Room in a three-person flat, Leipzig or similar.
Insurance	EUR 146	Statutory student rate, 23 or older, no child.
Food	EUR 240	Cooking five nights a week, one canteen lunch a day.
Transport	EUR 0	Already inside the semester contribution.
Phone	EUR 15	Prepaid, 15 GB.
Broadcasting fee	EUR 18.36	Only if you are the registered tenant.
Study material	EUR 20	One book a semester, rest from the library.
Personal	EUR 80	Everything else.
Total	EUR 949	Against a blocked account release of 992.

Notice how thin the margin is. Forty-three euros a month is not a buffer. That is why almost every Indian student in Germany works, and why chapter 9 matters.

Two ways to cut 150 euros a month

Move one city out. Living in a smaller university town and commuting, or choosing a cheaper city outright, saves more than any other decision you will make.

Take the dormitory offer even if it is not your first choice, and keep applying to the Studierendenwerk every semester. The waiting list moves.

PART TWO · CHAPTER 8

Scholarships an Indian student can actually win

Most scholarship lists you will find online are copied from each other and include programmes Indians are not eligible for. Here is what the DAAD database actually says, with the awkward parts left in.

The one that surprises people

DAAD's Study Scholarships for Master Studies in All Academic Disciplines, the big general master's scholarship, does not list India as an eligible country for the 2027/28 cycle. If a consultancy is selling you a package to apply for it, ask which country list they are reading. For India, the realistic DAAD routes are the ones below.

Programme	Who it is for	Money	How you apply
EPOS, Development-Related Postgraduate Courses	Graduates with at least two years of relevant professional experience, from eligible developing and emerging countries	EUR 992/month, insurance, travel, possible rent subsidy	Directly to the course, not to DAAD. Up to three courses, one motivation letter.
Helmut-Schmidt-Programme	Graduates in social and political sciences, law, economics, public policy and administration	EUR 992/month, insurance, travel, German course	Directly to the master's course, 1 June to 31 July for the following year.
Study scholarships for Fine Art, Design, Film and Performing Arts	Artists and designers	EUR 992/month	DAAD portal, with portfolio or work samples.
Doctoral programmes in Germany	Master's holders seeking a PhD	EUR 1,300/month, rising to EUR 1,400 from February 2026	DAAD portal plus a posted summary.
University summer courses	Bachelor's and master's students improving German	Course and travel support	30 October each year, from 1 September.

Two details from the EPOS rules that decide applications. You need a bachelor's degree normally of four years, at least two years of relevant professional experience after it, and your degrees should normally be no more than six years old. Applicants who have lived in Germany for more than fifteen months at the deadline are excluded. If you are a fresh graduate with no work experience, EPOS is not open to you, whatever an agent says.

Also note what the DAAD requires from Indian applicants specifically: EPOS courses at Freiburg, Charité Berlin and Oldenburg, and the Helmut-Schmidt programme, all ask for an APS certificate with the application. Start APS before you start the scholarship file, not after.

Deutschlandstipendium: small, real, and underused

The Deutschlandstipendium pays 300 euros a month, fixed by the scholarship programme act, and it is awarded by the university, not by a central body. Half the money comes from private sponsors, half from the federal government. Almost every German university participates, applications are usually open to students already enrolled, and the selection weighs grades and social engagement. It will not fund your degree, but 300 euros a month is a third of your rent.

Other places the money actually is

1. **University scholarships.** Most universities have a small fund for international students, often 500 to 1,800 euros a semester, awarded on grades and need. Search your university's international office page, not a blog.
2. **State and party foundations.** The eleven Begabtenförderung organisations fund students of all nationalities, but most expect German and a record of social engagement. Worth trying in your second semester.
3. **Employer sponsorship.** Rare in Germany, but some companies fund a master's in exchange for a working commitment. Ask your Indian employer before you resign.
4. **Indian government schemes.** The National Scholarship Portal carries overseas schemes from time to time. Deadlines are short and documentation is heavy; check it quarterly.
5. **Education loans.** The practical funding route for most Indian families. The German missions accept loan proof alongside the blocked account, and some banks will sanction against the admission letter and the blocked account confirmation.

PART TWO · CHAPTER 9

Working while studying: the legal maths

This is where a small misunderstanding becomes an immigration problem. The rules are generous, but they are specific, and they are counted in days, not hours.

The rule

With a residence permit for study purposes, you may work up to 140 full days or 280 half days a year. That is the statutory formulation in section 16b(3) of the Residence Act, and it has applied since 1 March 2024, replacing the older 120 full-day rule. Two conditions sit alongside it: part-time student jobs at the university, the so-called studentische Nebentätigkeit, do not count against the quota, and self-employment is not permitted on a student permit.

A half day means up to four hours. So 280 half days is 280 four-hour shifts, roughly 1,120 hours a year. Spread across twelve months that is about 93 hours a month, or a bit over 21 hours a week.

What that is worth in money

The statutory minimum wage rose to 13.90 euros an hour on 1 January 2026 and is set to rise to 14.60 euros on 1 January 2027. At 13.90, ninety-three hours a month grosses about 1,293 euros. That is more than the blocked account release. It is also why the day-count matters: exceed it and your next residence permit can be refused or your permit revoked.

Item	2026	2027
Statutory minimum wage	EUR 13.90/hour	EUR 14.60/hour
Mini-job earnings limit	EUR 603/month	EUR 633/month
Mid-job band	EUR 603.01 to EUR 2,000/month	Upper limit unchanged at EUR 2,000
Work allowance for non-EU students	140 full days or 280 half days a year	unchanged

Tax and social contributions

A mini-job up to 603 euros a month is exempt from income tax and from employee social contributions; the employer pays a flat charge. Above that, you enter the mid-job band with reduced employee contributions, and above 2,000 euros a month you pay the full rate. Income tax starts only above the basic allowance, which is 12,348 euros a year for a single person in 2026, so most students working within the day limit pay little or no income tax, and many can reclaim what was withheld.

The four jobs Indian students actually get

1. **Werkstudent**, a working-student role in a company, usually 15 to 20 hours a week in your field. Best paid, best for your CV, hardest to get without German.
2. **HiWi**, a research or teaching assistant at your university, often 40 to 60 hours a month. Badly paid by German standards, excellent for references, and usually flexible around exams.
3. **Hospitality and retail.** The reliable fallback. Supermarkets, cafés, kitchens, warehouses. German at A2 is enough for many roles.

4 **Delivery and logistics.** Physically hard, available immediately, and the one that eats your day quota fastest.

The calendar trick that saves students

Your 140-day allowance is per calendar year, not per academic year. A student who works heavily from September to December and then again from January can use two full allowances within five months, provided each falls in its own calendar year. Ask your foreigners authority before you rely on it, and keep your own written record of every shift with dates and hours. When a permit renewal is questioned, that record is your defence.

Three things that get permits revoked

Working more than the day allowance, even by a few shifts, because the tax office reports your hours and the foreigners authority reads the same data.

Registering as self-employed, for example as a freelance designer or delivery rider on a platform contract, on a student permit. That requires a different permission.

Letting an employer pay you off the books. It removes your only proof of lawful work and creates a tax problem you cannot fix later.

PART THREE · CHAPTER 10

APS: the Rs 18,000 step that sets your timeline

The Academic Evaluation Centre, APS India, sits inside the science section of the German Embassy in New Delhi. It verifies your Indian academic documents with the boards and universities that issued them. Its certificate is part of the standard documentation for a German student visa, and most Indian applicants cannot be admitted without it.

Who needs it, and who does not

If you obtained your school-leaving certificate in India, or have studied semesters or completed a degree in India, you almost always need the APS certificate. The German missions in India list five exemptions, and they are narrower than people assume.

Exempt if	Careful because
You are doing a PhD or postdoc in Germany	Master's applicants are not covered by this.
You hold a scholarship from EU or German public funds	A private scholarship does not count.
You are earning a non-German degree in Germany	The 18-month post-study permit rules differ for these.
Your degree is not Indian, for example a UK or US degree	An Indian bachelor's plus a foreign master's still needs care.
Your school-leaving certificate or degree is international, such as the IB	An Indian board certificate is not international.

If you fall outside all five, budget for APS and start early. APS does not ask for an admission letter, which means you can begin the moment you decide Germany is on your list.

The process, in the order it happens

1. **Check which procedure applies to you.** APS runs different procedures for undergraduates with two or more semesters, bachelor's and master's degree holders, and other groups. Read the leaflet for your group, not a generic blog.
2. **Register online at aps-india.de** and print the completed form. Sign it yourself. Incomplete or incorrect data invalidates the application.
3. **Pay Rs 18,000.** Use the CCAvenue option during registration. A manual bank transfer to the APS account forces manual account activation and lengthens processing. The fee is non-refundable once paid, whatever the outcome.
4. **Take dMAT first, if it applies to you.** From the summer semester 2027 master's intake, listed subject groups must submit a dMAT certificate from g.a.s.t. Chapter 11 covers this in detail.
5. **Courier the documents** to APS India, Gate No. 3, DLTA Complex, R.K. Khanna Stadium, 1 Africa Avenue, New Delhi 110029. Do not send originals. Keep your courier tracking number; APS does not give individual delivery updates.
6. **Warn your college and board.** APS verifies with them directly, and it accepts only official institutional confirmation. A reply from a Gmail address does not count. If your institution does not respond, your status becomes non-support and your file waits.

7. **Track the status in your APS account.** When verification succeeds you receive a digitally signed PDF certificate by email.
8. **Submit the certificate unchanged.** Do not rename, edit or merge the file. Send the original PDF to universities, to uni-assist and to VFS.

How long it takes, honestly

APS India states verification takes at least two weeks and declines to give a fixed timeline, because it depends on application volume and on how fast your institutions reply. In practice, complete files with responsive colleges come back in two to four weeks, and files sent between May and August can take two to three months. Build your calendar around the slow case, not the fast one.

> **The sequence that actually works**
> Decide on Germany in month zero. Register for APS in month zero or one. Take dMAT in the cycle that fits. Build your shortlist while APS runs. Apply to universities as soon as the APS PDF arrives. Book the visa slot the day your admission letter comes. Do not wait for APS before you shortlist, and do not apply before APS if the programme requires it at the application stage.

Five reasons APS files stall

1. Documents sent without the printed, personally signed application form.
2. Payment made by manual transfer and never matched to the profile.
3. Mark sheets missing for one semester, or a degree certificate without the final consolidated marksheet.
4. The college does not reply to APS's verification request, and nobody follows up.
5. A name mismatch between the passport, the mark sheets and the application form. Fix it in the application, not in the file.

PART THREE · CHAPTER 11

dMAT: the new test for 2027 master's applicants

This is the newest rule in the entire process and the one most applicants will discover too late. If you are applying for a master's in engineering, commerce, economics, finance or management from the summer semester 2027 intake onwards, a test now sits inside your APS file.

What dMAT is

dMAT is the Digital Master Test, administered by g.a.s.t., the organisation behind TestDaF and TestAS. APS India added it as an element of APS documentation for selected master's applicants whose previous degree falls within engineering, commerce, accounting, finance, economics, or business and management.

Who it applies to, precisely

The trigger is stated on the APS India dMAT page, published and last updated on 29 October 2026. It applies if all three of these are true:

1. Your APS online registration was completed on or after 29 June 2026, and your APS documents were shipped on or after that date.
2. Your previous degree falls within one of the affected subject fields: engineering, commerce, accounting, finance, economics, or business and management.
3. Your application relates to the summer semester 2027 master's intake or a later master's intake.

If you registered before that date, or your degree is in another field, or you are applying for a bachelor's programme, this does not apply to you. Check your own case against the APS page rather than a summary, including this one.

The dates and the money

Item	Detail
Test fee	EUR 150, paid to g.a.s.t. during registration
Cycle 1 date	16 January 2027
Cycle 2 date	13 March 2027
Registration	Open, through the g.a.s.t. portal, with date and location chosen at registration
Where it fits	Take it before you submit APS documents, or submit APS documents first and add the certificate later

The one useful piece of flexibility

APS India has said that applicants in the affected subject groups may submit their complete APS application documents now, before the dMAT certificate is available, so that document verification can begin in advance. All other documents required by the checklist must be in that first submission. The APS certificate itself is issued only after the dMAT certificate has been submitted and checked against g.a.s.t.'s data.

That is a real advantage if you use it. Send the file early, take the test in January or March, and your verification is already running while you wait for the result. Students who wait for the certificate before sending anything lose two months.

Do not treat dMAT as an afterthought

A missing dMAT certificate blocks the APS certificate, which blocks admission confirmation and the visa file. If your target is summer semester 2027, the 16 January 2027 cycle is effectively your only comfortable option, and the 13 March cycle leaves very little room before German application deadlines.

PART THREE · CHAPTER 12

Shortlisting: anabin, NC-free and English-taught

The most common expensive mistake Indian applicants make is choosing universities by ranking, then discovering that their degree does not qualify for that programme, or that the programme is taught in German, or that the deadline passed in January.

Check your eligibility before you fall in love

anabin is the German database that records how foreign school-leaving certificates and degrees are classified. It tells you whether your Indian 12th standard certificate gives direct access to a German university, or whether you need a Studienkolleg year first, and whether your Indian bachelor's is comparable to a German bachelor's.

For a master's, the practical rule is that a four-year Indian bachelor's in a relevant subject is usually accepted; a three-year degree is sometimes accepted and sometimes not, depending on the university and the programme. Do not rely on the general rule. Check the programme's admission requirements page, which will state the required ECTS credits in specific areas.

The three kinds of programme, and what each demands

Type	Language	What to know
German-taught bachelor's or master's	German, usually C1	Cheapest and most numerous. Requires a real certificate, not self-reported fluency.
English-taught master's	English, usually IELTS 6.5 or equivalent	The main route for Indian students. Competitive, and increasingly full of Indian applicants.
Studienkolleg then bachelor's	German, B1 to enter	For students whose 12th certificate does not give direct access. One extra year, and a Feststellungsprüfung at the end.

On language, one rule from the German missions in India is worth memorising: if you are entering degree studies directly, whether in German or in English, the missions generally expect level C1 in the language of instruction, proven by a recognised certificate. For a preparatory course in German, B1; for a preparatory course in English, B2. Many universities admit at a lower level than the visa section requires, which is how students end up admitted but refused. Chapter 15 has the full list.

Where to look, and how to filter

1. The DAAD International Programmes database, filtered by subject, degree level and language of instruction. It is the most complete single list.
2. Hochschulkompass, the German Rectors' Conference portal, for the full national list including universities of applied sciences.
3. The university's own programme page, for the admission requirements, the deadline and the exact tuition.
4. anabin, for whether your certificate qualifies.
5. uni-assist, for whether the programme requires you to apply through it, and whether it wants a VPD.

The shortlist that works: ten, six, three

Ten programmes you would be happy to attend. Six where your grades are at or above the stated average of last year's admitted class. Three where you would accept an offer without hesitating. Apply to all of the six. A single application is not a strategy, and German universities do not coordinate with each other, so applying to several costs you only the uni-assist fee per course.

PART THREE · CHAPTER 13

uni-assist and the VPD

uni-assist is a central service that evaluates international applications on behalf of many, though not all, German universities. Some universities require you to apply through it. Others use it only to issue a preliminary review document, the Vorprüfungsdokumentation or VPD, which you then submit yourself to the university.

What it costs

Item	Fee
First chosen course of study, per semester	EUR 75
Each additional chosen course, same semester	EUR 30
VPD procedure	Same fees as a standard application
Reapplying in a later semester	EUR 75 again for the first course

The fee is charged per chosen course, not per university. Two courses at one university and one at another is 75 plus 30 plus 30, so 135 euros for the semester. It is payable whether or not the evaluation is positive, and some universities cover it themselves, which you will see noted in your selection list.

The VPD, and why it breaks timelines

A VPD is a document that states how your foreign certificate is evaluated. Universities that use it usually require you to apply for the VPD first, wait, then submit the VPD with your actual programme application before the university's own deadline. Uni-assist and the universities that use it quote four to eight weeks for issue.

This is the trap: in the VPD procedure, the university's deadline applies to the arrival of your complete application including the VPD, not to the date you requested the VPD. If the deadline is 15 January and the VPD takes six weeks, your real start date is early December at the latest.

The practical sequence

1. Confirm on the programme page whether it uses the standard uni-assist procedure, the VPD procedure, a direct application, or Hochschulstart's DoSV for undergraduate medicine and similar.
2. Create your My assist account and enter every application you plan to make in the same semester before you pay. That is how the 75-plus-30 pricing works in your favour.
3. Upload clear scans, plus English or German translations where the document is not in either language. Certified copies are usually not needed at this stage.
4. Pay by card if you can. A bank transfer has to clear and appear as credit before you can submit, and that gap has cost applicants a deadline.
5. Watch your account for the evaluation result, and keep the PDF. For a VPD, submit it to the university yourself, in the format they ask for.

Two things uni-assist itself warns about

It does not work with commercial agencies that place applicants at German universities, and it says so on its own payment page. Organisations claiming affiliation exist. Payment requests come only through the uni-assist portal. The fee covers evaluation, not outcome. A negative evaluation is not refunded.

PART THREE · CHAPTER 14

SOP, CV and LOR written for German readers

Indian applicants write statements of purpose for admissions committees in the United States: ambition, leadership, transformation, a childhood dream. German readers are different. They want evidence, fit and clarity, and they are suspicious of adjectives.

What the visa section asks for, separately

Do not confuse the two documents. The German missions in India require, for a student visa, a freely written motivation letter explaining why you want to study in Germany, why this specific degree programme and university, how you found the university, and what your plans are after graduation. They also require a CV in table form in English or German, listing all previous training, qualifications and activities.

That motivation letter is not the same as a university SOP, though it can share content. It is read by a visa officer checking whether your story is coherent. If you claim you will return to India and your letter says you want to settle in Germany, expect questions.

The four-paragraph structure that works

1. **What you have done, concretely.** Your degree, your final-year project, one piece of work you can describe in technical detail. No adjectives about passion.
2. **What gap you are closing.** Name the specific modules or methods you need and do not have. This is the paragraph that shows you read the curriculum.
3. **Why this programme and this university.** Two named modules, one named professor or research group, one facility. Generic praise of German education is filler and reads as filler.
4. **What happens after.** A specific plan, in either country, that makes sense given your background. If you plan to return to India, say what role and which sector.

One page is enough. German readers do not reward length, and the visa section reads hundreds of these a week.

The CV in table form

Tabular, reverse chronological, no photo unless asked, no marital status, no father's name, no declaration line at the bottom. Dates in the German format, month and year. Gaps of three months or more get a one-line explanation, because a gap you leave unexplained looks like something you are hiding.

Include	Leave out
Degrees, with institution, city, years and final grade	Photograph, unless the programme asks
Work and internships, with one line on what you did	Marital status, religion, caste, father's occupation
Projects, with the tools and the outcome	Declarations and signatures at the end
Language certificates with scores and dates	Hobbies with no relevance
Publications, patents, competitions	Soft-skill adjectives with no evidence

Letters of recommendation

Two letters is the norm, one academic and one professional if you have worked. The content that helps is comparative and specific: how this student ranked against a cohort, what they did that was unusual, and where they struggled and improved. A letter that says “hardworking and sincere” is worthless.

Ask your professor for a letter six weeks before the deadline, give them your CV, transcript and the list of programmes, and offer to draft nothing. If your college issues letters only on letterhead with a stamp and signature, confirm that early, because scanned copies with a digital signature are increasingly accepted but not everywhere.

The single best edit you can make

Delete every sentence that would be true of any other applicant. “I have always been passionate about engineering” could be written by two lakh people. “My final-year project measured the settling velocity of fly ash in a lab-scale column and the model failed above 40 per cent solids” could only be written by you.

PART THREE · CHAPTER 15

Language proof: what India accepts, what it rejects

This chapter will save some readers Rs 15,000 and three months. The German missions in India publish an explicit list, and it excludes three tests that Indian students commonly take.

The rule, in the missions' own terms

For direct entry to degree studies, whether the programme is taught in German or in English, the missions in India generally require level C1 in the language of instruction, proven by a recognised certificate. For a preparatory course taught in German, B1; for a preparatory course taught in English, B2. The missions note that their online questionnaire asks about German even when your programme is in English, and that in those cases you should read “English” for “German” and upload proof of English.

Language	Accepted by the missions in India	Not accepted
German	Goethe Institute or Max Mueller Bhavan, ÖSD, telc, TestDaF, DSH	Self-reported levels, certificates from unrecognised providers
English	IELTS, Cambridge Assessment English, TOEFL (test centre)	Duolingo, Pearson PTE, TOEFL Home Edition

Read that right-hand column again. Duolingo, PTE and the at-home TOEFL are not accepted for applications in India, however convenient they are and however many Indian universities accept them. If a consultant has told you otherwise, change consultants.

Which certificate to take, and when

Your situation	Take this	Typical lead time
English-taught master's	IELTS Academic, usually 6.5 overall with no band below 6.0	Book 6 to 8 weeks before you need the result
German-taught master's	Goethe C1 or TestDaF, 4x4 or better	Six to twelve months of study before the exam
Studienkolleg route	Goethe B1 or B2, depending on the college	Plan a year of German in India
Programme requires only B2	Take B2, but confirm what the visa section expects	The mission may still expect C1 for direct entry

The missions also accept the university's own confirmation of language proficiency where the admission letter states it. That is useful, but it does not remove the need for a recognised certificate in most cases, and it never removes the need for a coherent motivation letter in a language the officer can read.

German, even when you do not need it

India's ambassador to Germany made the point directly in October 2026: learning German improves job prospects, because Germany's workforce is ageing and employers need people who can operate in German. The practical version for a student is this. English gets you into the lecture hall. German gets you the internship, the working-student contract and the first job.

A realistic plan that costs little: A1 before you leave India, using a free app and one paid course; A2 in your first semester at the university's free language centre; B1 by the end of your second semester. B1 is also what shortens your route to permanent residence later, as chapter 27 explains.

Where to learn German in India, cheaply

Max Mueller Bhavan centres run structured courses with Goethe certification, in person and online, and their certificate is exactly what the visa section accepts. University language departments in most Indian cities run evening courses at a fraction of the cost, but confirm the exam they prepare you for. Whatever you choose, sit the certificate exam, because a course completion letter is not a language certificate.

PART FOUR · CHAPTER 16

The 2027 calendar: summer and winter intakes

Germany has two intakes and one of them is much easier for Indian applicants. Summer semester starts in April, winter semester in October. Winter has the larger course catalogue, more English-taught options and more seats; summer is smaller, faster and less crowded with applicants, which can work in your favour if your documents are already in order.

Two deadlines you will see everywhere

Most German universities use 15 January for the summer semester and 15 July for the winter semester, with variations by programme and by university. Some master's programmes close in December for winter, and some non-EU deadlines are earlier than the general one. There is no single national deadline, so treat the dates below as the spine and check each programme page for its own.

Summer semester 2027, working backwards from April

When	What has to be true
Now to December 2026	APS registered and documents couriered. Shortlist of ten built. Language certificate booked or in hand.
By 15 January 2027	University applications submitted, including uni-assist or VPD. This is the hard gate for most summer programmes.
16 January or 13 March 2027	dMAT cycle, if your subject group and intake require it.
February to March 2027	Admission letters arrive. Blocked account opened and funded. Visa slot booked the day the letter arrives.
March 2027	Visa appointment at VFS or the mission. Documents in two identical sets.
March to April 2027	Visa decision, typically six to eight weeks after the appointment. Flight booked only after the passport is back.
April 2027	Arrival, Anmeldung, bank account, insurance confirmation, enrolment.

Winter semester 2027/28, working backwards from October

When	What has to be true
November 2026 to February 2027	APS filed early, before the May to August crush. dMAT taken in the January or March cycle if it applies.
March to May 2027	Language test taken. Shortlist finalised. Fee waivers and scholarship applications filed where relevant.
By 15 July 2027	Applications submitted. VPD applications started by early May, because they take four to eight weeks.
July to August 2027	Admission letters. Blocked account funded at the amount in force, with the 2027 buffer.
August to September 2027	Visa appointment and decision. This is the busiest window of the year, so book early.
October 2027	Arrival and enrolment.

The two dates that decide everything

Your university deadline, which you cannot move, and your visa appointment, which you can only book once you have an admission letter. Everything else is negotiable. Build your plan from those two backwards, and add four weeks of slack for APS and four for the visa decision.

PART FOUR · CHAPTER 17

The Consular Services Portal, step by step

Germany has moved most national visa applications online, and for India this is now the default route, not an option. If a visa type is available in the Consular Services Portal, the missions state that it is obligatory to apply there.

Why this matters

The portal checks your file before you ever stand at a counter. You complete the form online, upload your documents, and the mission reviews them and tells you what is missing, through the portal. At the end you get a link to book the in-person appointment, where your fingerprints and photo are taken and the fee is paid. Turn up with a paper application for a visa type that is available online and it will not be accepted.

The sequence

1. **Pick the right visa type.** Choose “Study purposes and seeking a university place”. A questionnaire then routes you to the correct sub-type. Answer truthfully; you cannot change sub-type later without starting over.
2. **Answer the language question carefully.** The questionnaire asks about German even for English-taught programmes. If your programme is in English, read “English” where it says “German” and upload English proof. Answer “yes” to B2 German only if it is true.
3. **Choose the mission for where you live,** not your citizenship. Each German mission in India covers specific states and districts. Choosing the wrong one means your application is not processed and you are asked to delete it.
4. **Complete the form and upload documents.** You can save and return. Uploads follow the checklist for your visa type, and the portal explains each one.
5. **Submit for preliminary review.** The mission checks completeness and contacts you through the portal if something is missing.
6. **Book the appointment** using the link the portal gives you at the end, and attend with originals.

Documents the portal will ask for, for studies

The missions publish the full list on their studies page. In summary, expect to upload: a valid passport issued within the last ten years with at least two empty pages; your school leaving certificate or previous degree with mark sheets for every semester; proof of language skills; the APS certificate, or an anabin or ZAB confirmation if you are exempt; the admission letter; a motivation letter; a CV in table form; proof of financing; and proof of health insurance from your intended arrival date.

If you are going to a private university or paying tuition, add proof of the fee amount and proof that the first year's fees, or a substantial deposit, have been paid. The missions state that the first two semesters of tuition must be paid, which is a cash-flow fact you should know before you apply to a fee-charging programme.

What happens to your documents after the appointment

Your file is forwarded to the foreigners authority in the city where you will study, which is why the missions quote six to eight weeks rather than a few days. The authority's approval, not the mission's, is usually the slow step. You cannot speed it up by emailing the mission, and the missions say plainly that they will not pre-check files or give binding advice in advance.

PART FOUR · CHAPTER 18

The visa file, document by document

This is the chapter to print. Prepare two identical sets, all copies A4, and carry the originals to the appointment. The German missions in India require two sets and will ask for originals on the day.

Document	The detail that gets missed
Passport	Issued within the last ten years, at least two empty pages, valid beyond your planned stay.
Application form and declarations	Two copies, signed. Through the portal this is generated for you.
Photographs	Three current, identical, biometric.
APS certificate	The original digitally signed PDF. Do not edit, rename or merge it. Check the exemption list in chapter 10.
Admission letter	Must confirm the language of instruction, and state any conditions. A conditional offer needs the conditions spelled out.
Previous qualifications	12th and 10th mark sheets for bachelor's applicants; degree certificate and every semester's mark sheet for master's.
Language certificate	Not older than one year in the missions' checklist. Recognised providers only.
Proof of financing	Blocked account confirmation stating the total and the monthly amount, or a Verpflichtungserklärung, or a scholarship letter.
Tuition proof, if any	Fee amount plus evidence of payment for the first year, or a substantial deposit.
CV	Table form, English or German, no gaps left unexplained.
Motivation letter	Signed, one page, explaining why Germany, why this programme, why this university, and your plan after.
Travel health insurance	Covering the first 90 days, starting on or before your intended date of entry. If it starts later, the visa starts later.
Visa fee	Rs 8,300 or EUR 75 for adults, payable in rupees at the exchange rate on the day, plus the service provider's fee.

The three documents that cause the most refusals

In practice, files fail on the same three items. Proof of financing that does not state the monthly release amount. A motivation letter that contradicts the rest of the file. And health insurance whose start date is later than the intended date of entry, which forces the mission to shorten the visa rather than refuse it, but which can also derail your enrolment date.

What the missions will not accept

1. Notarised or attested copies in place of originals, or Indian notary certifications in place of German ones. The missions state that certifications by Indian authorities or notaries are not accepted where certification is required.
2. An Indian affidavit of support in place of a blocked account or a German Verpflichtungserklärung. It is an additional document, not a substitute.

3. A blocked account confirmation without the total amount and the monthly amount.
4. A language certificate from a provider outside the recognised list, including Duolingo, PTE and TOEFL Home Edition.
5. Apostille or attestation as a substitute for verification. The missions say apostille is not recognised for visa purposes, though documents may still be verified for authenticity.

The two-hour check that prevents a refusal

Lay every document on the floor in the order of the checklist. For each one, ask three questions: does the name match my passport exactly, does the date fit the story, and does this document say what the checklist says it must say. Most refusals are one of those three, and all three are fixable before you pay the fee.

PART FOUR · CHAPTER 19

Twelve refusal reasons and how to pre-empt them

A refusal is not usually about your ability. It is about doubt: doubt that the money is real, doubt that the purpose is study, doubt that you will leave when the permit ends. Each of the twelve below creates that doubt, and each is preventable.

1. **Funds not demonstrably yours or your sponsor's.** A large deposit that appeared two weeks ago with no explanation is the classic trigger. Keep six months of bank statements and a written explanation of where the money came from.
2. **Blocked account confirmation without the monthly amount.** Ask the provider for the version that states both figures.
3. **Language level below what the programme or the mission expects.** The mission can refuse even when the university admitted you.
4. **Motivation letter that does not match the programme.** Copy-pasted letters that name the wrong university are refused routinely.
5. **Programme that does not look like a credible academic progression.** A sudden switch of subject with no explanation invites the question of whether study is the real purpose.
6. **Private programme with unpaid tuition.** The missions require proof of the first two semesters' fees or a substantial deposit.
7. **Missing APS certificate, or an APS certificate that does not cover your qualification.**
8. **Documents inconsistent with each other.** Different spellings of your name, different dates of employment, a CV that contradicts the motivation letter.
9. **Health insurance starting after the intended entry date.** It shortens the visa and can break your enrolment.
10. **Intent to work rather than study.** A letter that talks about earning and settling, with no academic content, is the fastest way to a refusal.
11. **Wrong mission or wrong visa sub-type.** Procedural, but it costs a month.
12. **Incomplete file.** The single most common and most avoidable reason.

If you are refused

Read the reasons in the decision letter carefully. A refusal on documents can often be addressed by a fresh application with the gap fixed; a refusal on a substantive ground such as credibility is harder and may need a remonstration, a formal objection, which is usually handled in German and within a stated deadline. Do not send a second application the same week with the same file. Fix the specific reason first, and get advice from the mission's published guidance rather than from an agent who profits from a second attempt.

Never do this

Do not submit a document that is not genuine, and do not let anyone improve a bank statement, an employment letter or a certificate for you. The missions state that false information or false documents lead to refusal and possibly an entry ban, and that ban follows you into every Schengen country, not just Germany.

PART FOUR · CHAPTER 20

Appointments, waiting, and what to do when it slips

The appointment is the part of this process you control least. Understanding how it works removes most of the panic.

How booking works

Appointments are booked through VFS Global for most student applications, and through the mission's own system in some consular districts. The missions are explicit that one appointment is needed per applicant, that the category must match your purpose of stay, and that early appointments are granted only in extreme medical or humanitarian cases. There is no queue-jumping route, and anyone selling one is selling you a refusal.

The missions also state clearly that agents are not necessary, that all forms and information are free, and that false information or documents lead to refusal and possible entry ban. If an agent offers to book a slot for a fee, you are paying for something you can do yourself in twenty minutes.

How long the decision takes

The student visa checklist published by the missions in India states that, because your application is forwarded to the foreigners authority in Germany, processing takes six to eight weeks. Treat eight weeks as the planning number and ten as the bad case. The decision arrives when your passport comes back, not before.

Stage	Realistic time	What you can do about it
Appointment availability	Days to several weeks, worse in July to September	Book the day your admission letter arrives, and check at off-peak hours
Appointment itself	One to two hours	Arrive early with two complete sets and all originals
Mission and authority processing	Six to eight weeks	Nothing. Do not email for status within four weeks
Passport return	A few days by courier	Track the VFS reference, keep it safe

If the semester starts before your visa arrives

1. Tell your university's international office immediately. Most will allow late enrolment, or deferral to the next semester, if you explain with evidence.
2. Ask the programme whether you can start online for the first weeks. Some allow it, many do not, and the answer affects your residence permit timing.
3. Do not book a non-refundable flight before the passport is back. Buy flexible or book late; the fare difference is smaller than a lost ticket.
4. If the delay crosses the semester start by more than four weeks, consider deferring formally. Arriving three weeks late is manageable. Arriving after the enrolment deadline is not.

The buffer rule

Book your visa appointment for a date at least ten weeks before your semester starts. If the only slot is later than that, take it anyway and tell your university. A late slot you hold is worth more than a perfect slot you cannot get.

PART FIVE · CHAPTER 21

Your first fourteen days

The first fortnight decides your first semester. Four things must happen in a specific order, and one of them has a legal deadline.

Day 1 to 3: the legal one

Register your address at the local residents' registration office, the Bürgeramt or Meldeamt, within two weeks of moving in. You need your passport, your rental contract or a landlord confirmation signed by the person who owns the flat, and the city's registration form. You will receive a registration certificate, the Meldebescheinigung, and that single piece of paper unlocks almost everything else: the bank account, the tax ID, the residence permit application and often the enrolment.

Book the appointment before you land if the city allows it. In Berlin, Munich and Cologne the wait can run to several weeks, and a late registration is a small fine plus a large hassle.

Day 2 to 7: money that moves

1. **Activate the blocked account.** You need the registration certificate, your passport and a German bank account, or the provider's own account. The first monthly release usually arrives a few days to two weeks after activation.
2. **Open a German bank account.** A current account with an online bank is fastest, and many accept the registration certificate and passport for video identification. Until then, carry enough cash or a card that works in Germany for two to three weeks.
3. **Confirm health insurance.** If you chose a statutory fund, send them your enrolment certificate and they will issue the confirmation your university needs. Contributions start from the first day of the semester, not from the day you sign.

Day 3 to 10: enrolment

Enrolment, the Immatrikulation, is usually online plus a payment of the semester contribution. You will need the admission letter, the insurance confirmation, the registration certificate and proof of the contribution payment. In return you get your student ID, your university account and, in most cities, the Deutschlandsemesterticket.

Day 7 to 14: the residence permit clock

Your visa is an entry visa, usually valid for three to twelve months. You must apply for a residence permit at the foreigners authority, the Ausländerbehörde, before it expires, and in most cities you should book the appointment in your first week because the wait is long. Chapter 24 covers the documents.

The five-line landing checklist

Registration appointment booked or done. Blocked account activated. German bank account opened. Health insurance confirmed to the university. Residence permit appointment booked. If all five are done inside fourteen days, your semester will not be derailed by paperwork.

PART FIVE · CHAPTER 22

Finding a room without being cheated

Housing is the hardest part of moving to Germany, harder than the visa, and it is where Indian students lose the most money to fraud.

Start before you leave

Apply to the Studierendenwerk dormitory in your university city the day you accept your offer, even if you have no confirmation of admission yet. Waiting lists are long, dormitory places cover roughly one student in ten nationally, and the earlier you are on the list the better your chance of a room at 250 to 400 euros instead of a market room at 500 to 800.

The three routes, honestly compared

Route	Typical cost	Reality
Studierendenwerk dormitory	EUR 250-400	Cheapest and safest. Long waiting list, and you may get a room in a less convenient part of town.
Shared flat, WG	EUR 400-800	The normal route. You apply to several rooms, usually with a short introduction about yourself, and landlords choose.
Studio or one-room flat	EUR 600-1,000+	Rarely affordable on a blocked account. Often needs a Schufa credit report you do not yet have.
Temporary: hostel, sublet, Airbnb	EUR 400-900	Use for the first month while you search in person. Never sign a year-long contract before you have seen the room.

The scam that catches Indian students every year

Someone advertises a room at a good price, says they are abroad and cannot show it, and asks for a deposit and the first month's rent by transfer before you sign anything. The room does not exist. The money is gone, and German police will tell you there is little they can do about a transfer to an account that has been emptied.

1. Never transfer a deposit before you have seen the room, in person or on a live video call where the person walks around it.
2. Never transfer money to an individual's account for a flat you have not visited. Use a deposit account, a Mietkautionskonto, in your own name where possible.
3. Ask for the landlord's name and compare it with the Grundbuch or the previous tenant's contract. A real landlord can produce a contract on paper.
4. Be suspicious of any price more than 20 per cent below the city average. That is the hook.
5. Join your university's own housing groups and the Indian student association in your city. Most rooms move inside those networks before they reach a public site.

What a German rental contract contains

Read three lines before you sign: the Kaltmiete, which is rent without utilities; the Nebenkosten, which are the running costs; and the Warmmiete, which is the two together and the number you should compare with your budget. Check the notice period, usually three months, and whether the flat comes furnished, because furnished rooms have different notice rules.

A deposit of up to three months' cold rent is normal, and it must be paid into a separate deposit account that earns interest in your name. Ask for a receipt, always.

PART FIVE · CHAPTER 23

Bank, tax ID, insurance, phone: the admin hour

Four small tasks, all doable in an afternoon once you have the registration certificate, and all of them block something else if you skip them.

Task	Why it matters	What to bring
Current account, Girokonto	Your blocked account release, your salary and your rent all move through it	Passport, registration certificate, enrolment certificate, tax ID
Tax ID, Steuer-ID	Mailed to your registered address automatically after registration. Needed by any employer	Nothing. Wait for the letter, then keep it
Health insurance confirmation	Required for enrolment and for the residence permit	Enrolment certificate, passport, German address
Mobile number	Every appointment, every verification code, every landlord	Passport or registration certificate for a contract SIM

Broadcasting fee: the bill nobody expects

Every household in Germany pays a broadcasting contribution, the Rundfunkbeitrag, currently 18.36 euros a month, regardless of whether you own a television. It is per household, not per person, so if you live in a shared flat and one tenant is already registered and paying, you do not pay again. If you rent your own flat, you will receive a letter and must register. Check the current rate when the letter arrives; the amount has been stable for years but is set politically.

Insurance: what your 141 to 146 euros actually buys

Statutory student insurance covers doctor visits, hospital treatment, prescriptions and, since it includes long-term care insurance, the care component as well. It does not cover dental prosthetics fully, and it does not cover travel outside Germany beyond emergency treatment. Most Indian students add a cheap private liability insurance, a Haftpflichtversicherung, for a few euros a month, because a broken laptop or a flooded neighbour's ceiling is otherwise your personal bill.

The student rate applies until the end of the semester in which you turn 30, and it requires you to be enrolled. After that you move to voluntary insurance at a much higher rate, which is why students who take longer than planned should plan the cost. For a student aged 30 or over, voluntary public insurance runs to roughly 275 euros a month, which changes the budget completely.

PART FIVE · CHAPTER 24

The residence permit appointment

Your visa gets you in. The residence permit keeps you legal. Book the appointment in your first week, because the wait for a slot is measured in weeks and the permit must be applied for before your visa expires.

What to bring

Document	Note
Passport and current visa	Plus a copy of the data page
Biometric photo	One, current, 35 by 45 mm
Registration certificate	From the Meldeamt
Enrolment certificate	From your university, current semester
Proof of financing	Blocked account statement, scholarship letter or work contract covering the next period
Health insurance confirmation	Statutory or recognised private
Rental contract or landlord confirmation	Shows you have somewhere to live
Application form	The city's own form, usually downloadable, sometimes online
Fee	Around EUR 100 for a first issue, payable at the appointment

What you get, and for how long

A residence permit for study purposes, usually issued for one to three years depending on your programme and the officer's assessment, and often limited to your standard period of study. It carries the work permission described in chapter 9. If your studies run longer, you extend it with a fresh enrolment certificate and fresh proof of funds.

The one thing to ask at the counter

Ask the officer to confirm, in writing if possible, the exact work allowance printed on your permit and whether student jobs at the university are excluded from it. The statutory rule is 140 full days or 280 half days, but permits sometimes carry an additional remark, and the remark is what an employer will read.

PART SIX · CHAPTER 25

Eighteen months to find work

Germany's post-study rule is one of the most generous in the world, and most students underuse it because they do not understand what it permits.

The permit

After you successfully complete a degree at a German university, you can apply for a residence permit to look for work under section 20(3)1 of the Residence Act. It is issued for up to 18 months, it cannot be extended beyond that, and while you hold it you may work without restriction. The 18 months start when your successful completion is announced, not when you deregister or when your student permit expires.

Question	Answer
How long	Up to 18 months, one-off, not extendable
Can I work while searching	Yes, any employment, no additional permission needed
What must I prove	Livelihood secured for the period, health insurance, registration, degree certificate
Fee	Around EUR 100 at issue
When to apply	Before your student permit expires, ideally eight days or more before
Does it lead to permanent residence	Not directly. Two years in qualified employment does

The four mistakes graduates make

1. Waiting until the permit expires to apply. The application must be in before expiry, and the appointment wait alone can be three months.
2. Not securing livelihood for the full period. The authority will issue a shorter permit if you can only show six months of funds, and the total remains capped at 18.
3. Assuming the 18 months is a grace period for travel. It is a job-search permit, and the clock does not pause.
4. Ignoring German. The single biggest determinant of whether you convert the 18 months into a job is whether you can interview in German at B1 or above.

Where the jobs actually are for Indian graduates

Engineering, IT, data and finance roles in the Mittelstand, the mid-sized German companies that most foreign graduates have never heard of, hire steadily and complain about talent shortages. Large corporates hire in cycles and prefer German. Startups hire in English but pay less and are less stable. The realistic strategy is to apply to mid-sized companies in smaller cities, where your competition is thinner and your rent is lower.

PART SIX · CHAPTER 26

The EU Blue Card in 2026 numbers

The Blue Card is the residence title you want if you find a qualified job. It is granted on a salary threshold, not on a quota, and the thresholds for 2026 are published.

Route	Minimum gross salary, 2026
General Blue Card	EUR 50,700 a year
Shortage occupations, and graduates within three years of finishing	EUR 45,934.20 a year
IT specialists without a formal degree, with three years of experience in the last seven	EUR 45,934.20 a year

Two structural points make the lower threshold easier to use than it looks. First, the reduced figure applies to anyone who obtained their qualifying degree within the last three years, regardless of occupation, which covers most fresh graduates. Second, it applies to shortage occupations, which include mathematics, IT, natural sciences and technology, architecture, human medicine, dentistry, veterinary medicine, pharmacy, nursing and midwifery, and teaching.

The trade-off is procedural. At the higher salary the Federal Employment Agency does not have to approve; at the lower one it does, which adds weeks and can result in the agency requiring a higher salary than the minimum. Budget for that delay.

What the Blue Card gives you

1. A residence title tied to qualified employment, issued for up to four years, or for the duration of your contract plus three months.
2. Mobility inside the EU after twelve months of legal employment in Germany, under the EU-wide Blue Card rules.
3. A faster route to permanent residence: 21 months of qualified employment with B1 German, or 27 months with A1.
4. Family reunification without a German language requirement for the spouse in most cases.

The salary arithmetic to do before you accept an offer

A 45,934.20 euro offer meets the graduate threshold but leaves little room: at that salary your net is roughly 2,400 to 2,600 euros a month depending on tax class, and rent in Munich can take half of it. A 50,700 euro offer clears the general threshold, removes the employment agency step and gives you a cleaner file. If a company offers you 44,000, the Blue Card is not available and you would need a different residence title, so ask before you sign.

PART SIX · CHAPTER 27

Permanent residence and citizenship timeline

Germany changed its naturalisation law in June 2024, and the timeline most blogs quote is out of date. Here is the current shape of it, with the caveat that residence law is amended often.

Milestone	What it takes
Job-seeker permit	18 months after graduation, work allowed
Skilled worker permit or Blue Card	A qualified job offer matching your degree
Permanent residence as a Blue Card holder	21 months of qualified employment with B1 German, or 27 months with A1
Permanent residence as a skilled worker	Typically two years of qualified employment, plus language and pension contributions
Citizenship	Five years of lawful residence with B1 German, or three years with C1 and special integration achievements

Two practical notes. The pension contribution requirement for permanent residence is usually met automatically once you are employed and paying into the statutory scheme, but months spent as a student do not count towards the employment period. And the five-year citizenship clock generally runs from your first lawful residence, which for most students means the day you registered in Germany, not the day you graduated.

Dual citizenship is now permitted, which removes the old dilemma for Indian nationals. India itself does not allow dual citizenship, however, so taking German citizenship means giving up your Indian passport and moving to an OCI card. That is a decision with family and property consequences in India, and it belongs in a conversation with a lawyer, not a blog post.

PART SIX · CHAPTER 28

Plan B, honestly

A guide that only describes the successful path is not useful. Here are the four ways this plan commonly goes wrong, and what to do.

You do not get admitted

The cheapest fix is a wider net in the same cycle: apply to more programmes, including universities of applied sciences, which are less prestigious in rankings and often better connected to employers. The second fix is a deferred cycle with a stronger file: a published paper, a relevant internship, a better language score. The third is a different country with the same degree, and if you are going to consider that, consider it before you pay for APS again.

You get admitted but the visa is refused

Fix the specific reason and reapply, or defer your admission by one semester and use the time to strengthen the file. Universities grant deferrals routinely when the reason is documented. Do not pay a second agent to resubmit the same documents.

You arrive and cannot afford the second year

This is more common than anyone admits, and it is usually a rent problem rather than a tuition problem. Three levers, in order of speed: move to a cheaper city or a dormitory, increase your working hours within the day allowance, and apply for the university's own hardship fund, which exists at almost every German university and is underused by international students. A fourth lever is a top-up education loan from an Indian bank, which is slow but possible while you are still enrolled.

You graduate and do not find a job in 18 months

The permit ends and you must leave, but the degree does not disappear. Options that work from India include German companies' Indian subsidiaries, Indian firms serving German clients, and a return to Germany later on a Blue Card or an opportunity card once you have three years of experience. The opportunity card, section 20a of the Residence Act, lets you enter for up to a year to look for qualified work if you score six points on its system or hold a fully recognised qualification, with proof of 1,091 euros a month.

> **The one decision that protects all four scenarios**
>
> Keep your total borrowing below what a starting German salary can service, and keep a return ticket's worth of money untouched. Students who can afford to walk away make better decisions than students who cannot, and the difference shows up in every negotiation from rent to salary.

PART SEVEN · CHAPTER 29

Master document checklist

Print this page. Tick each line only when the document exists in the right form, with the right name spelling, and in the right number of copies.

Done	Document	Where it goes
	Passport, valid ten years, two blank pages	Visa file, university applications
	10th and 12th mark sheets and certificates	APS, uni-assist, visa
	Degree certificate and consolidated marksheet	APS, uni-assist, visa
	All semester mark sheets	APS, visa
	APS certificate, digitally signed PDF	Universities, uni-assist, VFS
	dMAT certificate, if your subject group requires it	APS
	Language certificate, recognised provider, under one year old	Universities, visa
	Admission letter stating language of instruction	Visa
	Blocked account confirmation with total and monthly amount	Visa
	Scholarship or loan sanction letter, if any	Visa, university
	Motivation letter, one page, signed	Visa, sometimes university
	CV in table form, no unexplained gaps	Visa, universities
	Two letters of recommendation, on letterhead	Universities
	Travel health insurance for the first 90 days	Visa
	Statutory health insurance confirmation	Enrolment, residence permit
	Three biometric photographs	Visa
	Two identical A4 sets of everything	Visa appointment

One habit that saves weeks: keep a single folder on your laptop named with the intake, for example summer-2027, with subfolders for APS, universities, visa and arrival. Save every document as a PDF with a name that a stranger could understand, such as marksheet-semester-5.pdf rather than scan0043.pdf. When a mission emails you asking for one document, you will find it in ten seconds instead of an hour.

PART SEVEN · CHAPTER 30

Budget and funding worksheet

Fill this in with your own numbers before you commit to an intake. The right-hand column is a worked example for a tuition-free master's in a mid-sized city, so you can see the shape of it.

Line	Your figure	Example
Blocked account required		EUR 11,904
Buffer for a 2027 increase		EUR 1,000
APS fee		Rs 18,000
dMAT fee, if applicable		EUR 150
uni-assist, six courses		EUR 225
Visa fee plus VFS service fee		Rs 8,300 plus service fee
Flight		Rs 45,000
Deposit and first month's rent		EUR 1,200
Setup: bedding, SIM, kitchen, bike		EUR 400
Total cash needed before landing		about EUR 15,000

Monthly plan

Head	Your figure	Example
Rent, warm		EUR 430
Health and care insurance		EUR 146
Food		EUR 240
Phone and internet		EUR 15
Broadcasting fee, if applicable		EUR 18
Study material		EUR 20
Personal		EUR 80
Monthly total		EUR 949
Monthly release from blocked account		EUR 992
Gap to cover from work		EUR 0 to 150

If the gap is positive, plan your working hours before you arrive, not after. If it is negative, you have a buffer, and the buffer should go into an emergency fund rather than into your monthly spending.

PART SEVEN · CHAPTER 31

Six email templates that get replies

German administrative email has a style: short, formal, specific, and it names the file number. Copy these, replace the bracketed parts, and keep them under 150 words. Write in English unless you are confident in German, and if you write in German, get it checked.

1. To a university, asking whether your degree qualifies

Subject: Eligibility enquiry, Master's in [subject], applicant ID [if any]
Dear Admissions Team,

I hold a four-year Bachelor of [degree] from [university], India, completed in [year] with [percentage or CGPA]. I intend to apply for the Master's in [programme] for [semester].

Could you confirm whether my degree meets the admission requirements, in particular the [number] ECTS in [subject area]? My transcripts are attached for reference.

Thank you for your time.

Kind regards,
[Full name], [phone], [email]

2. To APS India, when your file shows non-support

Subject: Request for status, APS application [registration number]
Dear APS Team,

My application [number] shows the status non-support, indicating that [name of institution] has not yet responded to your verification request. I have contacted the institution's examination section on [date] and requested an official reply to your office.

Could you confirm whether any further document from me would help complete verification? I am able to provide [specific document].

Kind regards,
[Full name], [registration number]

3. To a landlord, applying for a room

Subject: Application for the room at [address], [your name]
Dear [name],

I am a [age]-year-old master's student in [subject] at [university], starting [month]. I am a non-smoker, quiet, and I cook at home most days. I can provide a Schufa report, proof of enrolment, and confirmation of my blocked account or scholarship.

I would be happy to view the room on [dates] or by video call. I am available to sign from [date].

Kind regards,
[Full name], [phone]

4. To the foreigners authority, booking the residence permit

Subject: Appointment request, residence permit for study purposes, [name], [date of birth]
Dear Sir or Madam,

I entered Germany on [date] with a national visa for study purposes, valid until [date]. I am enrolled at [university] in [programme] and registered at [address] since [date].

I request an appointment to apply for a residence permit. I can bring my passport, registration certificate, enrolment certificate, proof of financing and health insurance confirmation.

Kind regards,
[Full name], [phone]

5. To a company, asking for a working-student role

Subject: Working student application, [role or department], [name]
Dear [name],

I am in my [first or second] semester of the Master's in [subject] at [university], with [number] years of experience in [skill] at [company] in India. I am available for [15 to 20] hours a week and can work [days].

I noticed your team works on [specific thing]. My experience with [specific tool or project] may be relevant. My CV is attached.

Kind regards,
[Full name], [phone]

6. To the university, requesting a deferral

Subject: Request to defer admission, [programme], applicant [number]

Dear Admissions Team,

I was admitted to the Master's in [programme] for [semester], applicant number [number]. My visa application was submitted on [date] and is still under processing at the German mission in [city], reference [number].

I request deferral of my admission to the next intake. I remain committed to joining and can provide the mission's acknowledgement of my application.

Kind regards,
[Full name]

PART SEVEN · CHAPTER 32

Twenty questions students actually ask

Is Germany really free?

For most public universities outside Baden-Württemberg and TUM, tuition is zero and you pay a semester contribution of roughly 90 to 350 euros. Baden-Württemberg charges non-EU students 1,500 euros a semester, and TUM charges 2,000 to 6,000 euros a semester depending on the programme, rising from winter semester 2027/28.

How much money do I need in total?

Around 15,000 euros of available cash before you land, of which 11,904 is the blocked account and comes back to you monthly. In rupees, roughly 15 to 17 lakh of liquidity.

Do I need APS if I have a master's already?

Yes, unless you fall inside one of the five exemptions. An Indian master's is still an Indian qualification. PhD and postdoc applicants are exempt.

Is dMAT compulsory for me?

Only if your APS registration and document shipment were on or after 29 June 2026, your previous degree is in engineering, commerce, accounting, finance, economics, business or management, and you are applying for the summer 2027 master's intake or later.

Can I apply without IELTS?

Sometimes, if your admission letter states the language of proficiency and the mission accepts it, or if your degree was taught in English and the university issues a medium-of-instruction certificate. Do not assume it. Duolingo and PTE are not accepted in India.

Is a three-year Indian bachelor's accepted?

Sometimes. It depends on the programme and on how anabin classifies your degree. Check the programme page for required ECTS and email the admissions office before applying.

How many universities should I apply to?

Six serious applications, spread across a reach, a match and a safe band. German universities do not coordinate, and each application is assessed on its own.

Can I work while studying?

Yes. 140 full days or 280 half days a year, plus student jobs at the university which do not count. Self-employment is not permitted on a student permit.

How much can I earn?

At the 2026 minimum wage of 13.90 euros an hour, working 93 hours a month grosses about 1,293 euros. That is roughly what the blocked account releases, so work doubles your monthly cash if you use the full allowance.

Will I get a dormitory room?

Not reliably. Dormitories house roughly one student in ten nationally, and about 33,000 students were waiting at the start of winter semester 2025/26. Apply the day you accept your offer and keep applying.

How long does the visa take?

Six to eight weeks after the appointment, per the missions' own checklist, because the file goes to the foreigners authority in Germany. Plan ten weeks.

What if my visa is late?

Tell your university immediately. Most allow late enrolment or a deferral with documented evidence. Never book a non-refundable flight before the passport returns.

Do I need a German bank account before I arrive?

No, but you need one to activate the blocked account. Until it exists, carry a card and enough cash for two to three weeks.

Is health insurance included in my fees?

No. Statutory student insurance is separate and costs about 141 to 146 euros a month from January 2026, depending on age and children.

Can my spouse come with me?

Family reunification for students is possible but requires proof of additional funds and space. It is a separate visa application with its own file, and the requirements are stricter than students expect.

Can I change my subject after arriving?

Changing programme or subject requires the foreigners authority's agreement and, in practice, a new admission. Do not assume you can switch in your second semester.

What happens after I graduate?

You can apply for an 18-month residence permit to look for work, and you may work without restriction during it. Then a Blue Card or a skilled-worker permit.

What salary do I need for a Blue Card?

50,700 euros a year in 2026, or 45,934.20 for shortage occupations and for graduates within three years of finishing.

How long until permanent residence?

21 months of qualified employment with B1 German on a Blue Card, or 27 months with A1. As a skilled worker, typically two years.

Is it worth it?

If you want a European credential, a legal route to work in the EU, and you can afford the two years without crippling debt, yes. If you need a job in eighteen months and cannot learn German, the arithmetic gets harder, and you should say so to yourself now rather than in your third semester.

PART SEVEN · CHAPTER 33

Glossary and sources

The German words on every form

Term	What it means
Anabin	The database that classifies foreign school and university qualifications
Anmeldung	Registering your address at the residents' registration office
APS	Academic Evaluation Centre, the document verification body at the German Embassy in New Delhi
AufenthG	The Residence Act, the law that sets visa and permit rules
Ausländerbehörde	The foreigners authority, where you apply for a residence permit
BAföG	Germany's student support law, which sets the blocked account amount
Blocked account, Sperrkonto	An account holding your living costs, released monthly
Consular Services Portal	The online portal for national visa applications
dMAT	Digital Master Test, required for listed master's subject groups from summer 2027
Deutschlandsemesterticket	The semester transport ticket, 37.80 euros a month from winter 2026/27
Immatrikulation	Enrolment at the university
Meldebescheinigung	The registration certificate you get after Anmeldung
Rundfunkbeitrag	The household broadcasting fee, 18.36 euros a month
Studierendenwerk	The student services organisation that runs dormitories and canteens
Studienkolleg	A one-year preparatory college for applicants whose school certificate does not give direct access
uni-assist	The central application service used by many universities
Verpflichtungserklärung	A formal obligation letter from a sponsor living in Germany
VPD	Preliminary review documentation issued by uni-assist
Werkstudent	A working-student role in a company

Sources used in this edition

Every figure was checked against these primary sources between 1 and 3 November 2026. Where a secondary source was used for context, it is named in the text.

1 German missions in India, india.diplo.de: National Visa page, 1 October 2026; Studies checklist and studies page, 16 February 2026; National Visa FAQs.

2 Consular Services Portal, digital.diplo.de: visa application process and study purposes pages.

3 Federal Foreign Office, auswaertiges-amt.de: blocked account (Sperrkonto) guidance and proof of finance.

4 APS India, aps-india.de: information leaflet for bachelor's and master's degree holders, valid as of June 2026; dMAT page, published 29 October 2026; FAQs.

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6 Make it in Germany, make-it-in-germany.com: EU Blue Card at a glance, as of January 2026; financial security minimum amounts, 2026; prospects after graduation; opportunity card.

7 Bundesagentur für Arbeit: Blue Card thresholds 2026.

8 Bundesportal, verwaltung.bund.de: residence permit to look for a job after graduation.

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10 Bundesregierung: minimum wage 2026 and 2027, and mini-job earnings limits.

11 Techniker Krankenkasse: student contributions from 1 January 2026.

12 Technische Universität München: tuition fees for non-EU students, semester fees, and the winter 2027/28 increase.

13 uni-assist e.V.: handling fees and payment page.

14 Deutsches Studierendenwerk and the Moses Mendelssohn Institute: student housing cost survey, winter semester 2025/26.

15 VRR and hvv: Deutschlandsemesterticket price from winter semester 2026/27.

A last word

The students who do well in Germany are rarely the ones with the best marks. They are the ones who started the paperwork six months before everyone else, kept their own copies of everything, and learned enough German to be in the room when decisions were made. None of that requires money. All of it requires deciding early.

If you take one thing from this book, take the calendar in chapter 16. Put the dates in your phone today, and work backwards.